

The hidden, but painful area of farm family conflict need not exist, if those involved knew how to communicate effectively. Mairead McGuinness talks to one man determined to help people help themselves.

Resolving farm family conflict

People suffer and the farm as a business suffers where there is poor communication and conflict, according to Jim Buckley of Millennium Management. The problem may be between father and son, between spouses on the farm or between the farmer and the farm workers. Yet, apart from dealing with the problems themselves, there has been nothing by way of professional help for those caught in the middle of a difficult situation.

Jim Buckley puts it very strongly when he says that there are fatalities when problems get out of hand and are left unchecked.

Millennium Management has just begun a series of courses called Farm Family Communications, which are targeted at the farming community and offering the same principles as are available to businesses where there are communication problems.

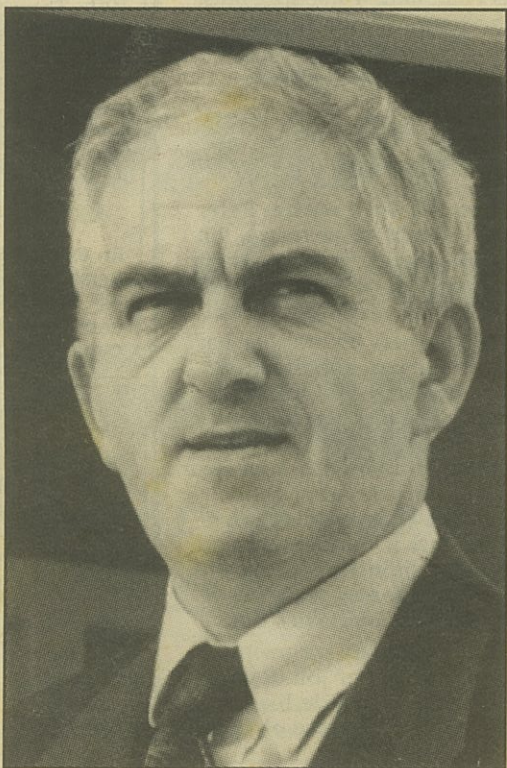
While Jim Buckley sees farming as a business, he stresses that the nature of farming, where a farmer often operates alone or where there is more than one generation working the farm, can lead to conflicts and difficulties.

"But knowing yourself and how you relate to others can be the key to making life better and farming more profitable", Jim says.

Experience

Jim knows from his own painful experience how farm families can sometimes run into problems. His own relationship with his father went through a difficult phase where there was virtually no communication between them for 15 months. Now, Jim says, they are the best of friends.

The key to the remarkable change is that Jim first



Jim Buckley



Raising funds for Bosnian women

Olive Braden of the Rape Crisis Centre (above) speaking at the ICA Auction held to support Bosnian women who have been the victims of rape and ethnic cleansing. The auction raised much needed funds to send aid to the war stricken area.

In addition, ICA president, Bridin Twist said that 60 places are being offered free of charge in the ICA's Adult Education College, An Grianan, to the victims of the war.

The funds raised at the auction will send a container of craft material accompanied by craft teachers to help in the rehabilitation of people who have suffered and are now exiled in the rape camps of Bosnia.

Bridin Twist called on the Tanaiste Dick Spring to bring pressure on the United Nations to bring the perpetrators of these atrocious war crimes to justice.

learned about himself and then about his father and how they both communicate.

"People are born with innate attributes and once we are more aware of ourselves and how others communicate, we can de-personalise things that are said or done and so take the emotion out of the situation."

In business Jim Buckley heads up a team of management consultants, called in by leading companies to help them cope with change and the management of change, to help them improve profitability and develop team work, which involves interpersonal communications.

Farmers rarely, if ever, call in management consultants to deal with interpersonal problems. In many cases they are not perceived as problems requiring professional help.

Priority

Calling in a management consultant to deal with husbandry problems like grass growth and feed conversion efficiencies is perfectly acceptable, facing up to problems in relationships, either within the family, or extended family or between farmer and farm worker is not given the priority it deserves.

The courses on farm family communication being offered by Millennium Management use the same techniques as would be used to help an electronics company's workforce work better as a team.

According to Jim, the nature of farming where a farmer often

works on his own means that farmers are not as exposed to other personality types and so find it difficult to communicate or adapt.

"It is much easier for a farmer to get into a rut than it is for a person who is going out to work on a daily basis and mixing with many different people.

"People who work away from the farm will be more adaptable to others," he says.

Frustration

Those who come to Jim's courses usually do so when they are in deep pain and where they are going through a very difficult time dealing with interpersonal problems.

"Many come out of a sense of frustration."

But many also come to learn about themselves, how they communicate and how they interact

with those they live and work with.

"I'm very practical about this - we are business driven and profit motivated, so our courses are designed to help people communicate better and so become more effective on their farms and ultimately make more profit.

"Sometimes a farm can be under performing because the farmer is experiencing pain and not getting on with those around them. Because he is unhappy the farm is suffering, even though he is a good farmer"

For people like this the courses offers an opportunity to look at themselves and how they interact with others and with the knowledge gained make improvements in their lives.

But it is not just people who are experiencing particular difficulties that find the courses of value.

Evening seminars

Millennium Management will hold a series of introductory evening seminars in three centres in December with the theme of helping farm families make 1996 a better year for communication, understanding and productivity.

Athlone on Monday 4th December,

Mallow, Tuesday 5th December,

Naas, Wednesday 6th December. The seminars will run from 7.30p.m. - 10.00p.m

The fee is £15 and Attendance is by reservation only to Millennium Management International at 066/21222 or fax 066 21999.

We want to hear from you, so keep your letters coming, keep them short and to the point and you could win our star prize of £10.

It is usually late at night, after a Macra rally or farmers' meeting, when the sensible ones have gone home that the stories of unhappiness, of misunderstandings and trauma all happening down on the farm; of sons not talking to fathers, of mothers caught in the middle, of young people leaving, never to return, all because those involved could not communicate, or when they tried, the language was all wrong and every effort to straighten the lines simply added to the bitterness and the rows.



Every parish has its cases - to say that every farm family has had its touch with such difficulties is hardly exaggerating the matter. Yet it gets no hearing at any level. There is no official recognition of its existence nor official help to assist those involved to come to terms with it.

It is the subject reserved for late nights and dingy corners in pubs, washed down with a few pints to ease the pain of the afflicted. Growing grass and boosting crop yields are easier topics to grapple with than the incredibly complex world of human relationships. Yet profitable farming is just as much about getting the personal relationships right as it is about getting herbicide application rates spot on. They are not mutually exclusive.

Put very simply, a happy man works well, does a good job and can rest easy at night. The rule is the same for women. But an unhappy man will find it difficult to concentrate, and so find it difficult to do the right thing on the farm and as a result the farm suffers. While that in itself is highly undesirable, what is much more alarming is the sadness and unhappiness suffered by the people involved.

Wasted years of bickering, of silences - and all down to an inability to communicate. So it was of more than passing curiosity that I read about new courses being offered to farm families in this complex area of improving communications.

The courses are being offered by **Jim Buckley of Millennium Management** who has been working as a management consultant in business for years. Jim will be well known in Macra na Feirme circles and perhaps he is coming back to his roots in recognising the need for such courses.

Talking to Jim about the subject, I detect more than a business opportunity being grabbed here. Jim believes that the trauma caused by difficult relationships on farms causes more human misery than anyone realises and on a more practical level he sees farms struggling as a result.

Jim Buckley believes that if people learn to understand themselves first and then others and how they communicate, then a great deal of the misunderstandings can be removed.

One young man who has benefited from the courses told me, "we are all very good at dealing with animal husbandry, but we know very little about ourselves and how to deal with conflict".

Since taking part this young man is better able to cope and deal with personal conflicts and is now able to farm effectively while also going back to college at night.

Getting out of a rut can seem impossible and can also be painful, but the end results of trying are worth it.

The evening seminars are worth a hearing (see page 1).

Mairead

Try that bag on, love!

Star letter £10

DEAR EDITOR, I read with laughter all the way through your article on November 11, regarding husbands shopping with wives. I can tell you, I left my husband at home years ago as the comment I would get when trying on anything would be, "it's alright". I thought to myself, if I put a bag on me, or the most expensive outfit, he would still say "it's alright", so therefore I leave him at home where he is happy mucking on the farm and I'm happy shopping on my own.

We both enjoyed your article so much that I just had to write to tell you so. Keep up the good work and congrats on that article as it really was as life is. God Bless.

● Galway reader.



Santa Bear took time out to visit his friends at the Central Remedial Clinic, and to launch the 'cutest' fundraising event of the year. The CRC Santa Bear Appeal will take place all over Ireland from Monday to Thursday December 4th - 14th. The Santa Bears, which wave the little CRC flag and wear Santa hats will be on sale throughout the country for a minimum donation of £1.

This is the third year of the Santa Bear Appeal, and Vivienne McCutcheon, Public Relations Director at the CRC, is confident that this appeal will continue for many years to come. The Clinic is planning to raise £150,000 for the children of the CRC, and is very hopeful that there will be strong support nationally for this appeal.

Vegetable marrow

DEAR EDITOR, I am wondering would any of your readers have any use for Vegetable Marrow. I have 30 of them and anyone can have them. I hate to see them go to waste.

● Name & address with editor

Nuisance phone calls

DEAR EDITOR, I firmly believe I have discovered a method of making nuisance phone callers end their stupid practice. Recently my phone caller decided to call at 11.30 pm. I answered only to be greeted with what I considered to be a stupid remark - obscene you could describe it. I replied cheerfully by enquiring "How is your health?" "O'h, I'm great", says he. "But how is your mental health?" I cheerfully enquired, whereupon the phone was left down, with haste needless to say.

I am thankfully not a frequent victim of nasty phone calls and anyone who is certainly has my sympathy, as nuisance is a mild word to describe such activity.

● The last word

Better off on the dole?

DEAR EDITOR, I wish to highlight the plight of many honest, hard working farmers, due to the awful tax demands they are getting. Most farmers are in heavy debt and many are getting it hard to keep up payments. Then to be advised to borrow more and pay off these taxes or else!

I think it's shameful and one farmer said to

me "I wish I never had bought land. I'd be far better off on the dole, free medical and dental care, and not stuck in the muck seven days a week."

If this is Labour's tactics as partners in Government, I think Mr. Bruton should pull the plug. Whoever was responsible for paying out single parent's allowance - it has put the teenagers daft and, worse still, most of the parents approve. Of course any money from the government is well won and the poor tax payer caught again.

● Strange but true

Valuing the real 'landlady'

DEAR EDITOR, After reading your star letter of November 4, a thought came to me. I'm prepared to pay £55 a week from my grant money (because I can find nothing cheaper) for five nights B&B and four evening meals.

For the past eighteen years my mother has provided the above for me, like thousands of other mothers, and an awful lot more without ever getting a penny. The person to whom I hand over £55 per week has the fancy title 'landlady'. Mothers like mine get no money and have no title other than housewife or farmer's wife. A quick calculation would show that if mothers around Ireland were valued in monetary terms, the total would be £51,480 for 18 years (excluding weekends which landladies do).

Isn't that some value to place on people who don't even have a proper job description. How could a mundane title like 'housewife' really reflect the value of these people.

● Landlady fan!

Notice Board

CORRECTION

The 'phone number published in last week's *Journal Plus* for the Skiing Shamrocks, a Munster based ski group, was incorrect. All you ski enthusiasts can contact the group at 063-89591 for your trip of a lifetime to Andorra in January.

Messiah Performance

St. Patrick's Hospital, in association with The Culwick Choral Society, will present a performance of Handel's Messiah to celebrate St. Patrick's Hospital 250th anniversary, in St. Patrick's Cathedral, Dublin, on Wednesday and Thursday, 6 & 7 December at 8 pm.

Tickets £12.50 available from McCullough Pigott (01-6773138) or credit cards 01-6775423.

Bartlemy Craft and Gift Fair

Bartlemy, Co. Cork, are holding a craft and gift fair in Bartlemy Hall on Sunday, December 3. Bookings for stands are now being taken. Last year there were 20 stands with jewelry, knitwear, ceramics, books, models, preserves, woodwork, pictures, etc. They are hoping for even more this year. Nominal fee for stands which can be booked by phoning 025/36715.

Railway Preservation Society of Ireland

Santa Steam Trains at Pearse Railway Station, Westland Row, Dublin. Sunday December 3rd and Sunday December 10th. Three trains on each day departing at 10.45am: 2.00pm: 4.20pm. Fare - All inclusive one price ticket - child or adult - £6 return.

Flower paintings by Geraldine O'Brien

An exhibition of flower paintings by Geraldine O'Brien is running at Frank Lewis Gallery, 6 Bridewell Lane, Killarney until December 2, from 9 am - 6 pm Monday to Saturday.

Wood of life

Irish Woodworkers for Africa present *Wood of Life*, illustrating the importance of wood in our lives, at Enfo, 17 St. Andrew St., Dublin 2. The exhibition runs until January 6, 1996, 10am - 5pm, Monday - Saturday.

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Resolving farm family conflict

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JIM recently spoke to the Damer farm discussion group in Nenagh and Padraig Walshe told Journal Plus about his impressions.

"As a group we are constantly looking at ways of improving ourselves and our achievements. Jim gave us a preliminary course, which I can only describe as fantastic.

"Of course people have to follow up on what they get from the course, but anything which helps to improve relationships between people must be of immense value. It can apply to relationships in the family itself, in the extended family, between the farmer and the workmen. Our discussion group hopes to organise a full course shortly."

Padraig says that it is difficult to explain exactly what is involved in the courses; "but basically it is about understanding yourself first and understanding what makes other people tick - it sound simple, but it's an extremely complex subject.

Perhaps one of the most difficult areas of conflict arises between the



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older and younger generation on the farm.

"This conflict between the two generations can be very difficult and often both sides lose out, according to Jim.

"Very often the older farmer sees that if he gives over the land to the son he is giving away his self esteem. Then if he is not getting on with his son, this too is haunting him. Sometimes the son will leave and then both parties suffer."

However, Jim maintains that if the young person changes by learning about how he communicates, this can often lead to a change in the attitude of the older person.

"And if the parents do not change then there are ways of dealing with that too."

He says that on many farms where there is conflict, the arguments keep going around in circles.

"People need to pull back from this vicious circle and take a look at what is actually happening. Constantly arguing about the same issues can be a wasted process, just muddying the waters, without solving the problem," he adds.

To a young person who finds themselves in this situation, Jim says that there needs to be a belief there that the issue can be sorted out one way or the other.

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IRISH COUNTRY Living

"But I would also stress that people should realise that it need not all be resolved tomorrow."

The courses run by Millennium Management will not solve individual family problems and difficult relationships, but they will provide people with the skills needed to find the solutions

themselves.

"Sometimes, a person will still arrive at the conclusion that they must move away," Jim says.

But where people find a way of breaking out of the trauma they are living in, many just take off and their farming improves dramatically, he adds.